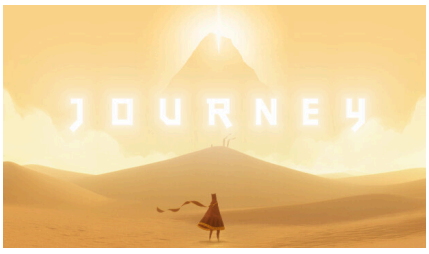
Monarch

What is *“Monarch”*?

Monarch is a 2D metroidvania, where the player represents the Young Girl living in a world much bigger than herself. The player’s goal is to explore the world through a combination of platforming and combat, gaining more control over their abilities and surroundings as they play. This game blends the popular ability based progression gameplay seen in classic metroidvanias like *Hollow Knight*, with a deeper focus on storytelling like *Journey* and *Gris*.



+


=Monarch

Design Pillars

What is the central experience we want players to have, and what design choices should we make to get there?

Immersion	Discovery	Application of a Skill
Players will gain fulfillment through following the Young Girl’s story. They will get a feeling of vicarious success as she overcomes daunting challenges and finds her footing in the world.	As they play the game, players will encounter new and exciting areas that will build their understanding of the world around them. The nonlinear gameplay will allow players to not only find enjoyment in the unknown, but also return to previously explored areas with a new perspective and skillset.	Players will be placed in a world much bigger than their character, and will have to learn how to traverse it through platforming and combat. Over the course of the game, they will become more skilled in these areas and be given opportunities to apply these skills through various challenges. Overcoming these challenges will give the player a feeling of triumph and success.

Audience and Market

The game is designed to be sold and played online as a single-player via Steam.

The main story will explore themes of femininity, control, and self discovery, geared towards a teen-adult, female audience.

Core Gameplay

Players will use the left and right arrow keys to move the Young Girl in their respective directions, and the SPACE bar will be used to jump.

For combat, the Young Girl will wield the branch of an oak tree as a weapon and an oak leaf as a shield:

- Players can press the Z key to attack with their weapon.
- Players can press and hold the X key to raise their shield and block attacks from enemies.
- Players cannot hold up their shield and attack with their weapon at the same time. When a player attacks with their weapon, their shield is lowered leaving them vulnerable to damage.

Items can be gained throughout the course of the game to increase the player's skill set:

- Acorn cap
    - A stronger shield that can be used in place of the oak leaf (X). This sturdier shield can be raised at the right time to parry an enemy attack, leaving them vulnerable to take damage.
- Wings
    - Allows the player to double jump (press the SPACE bar multiple times and jump once more while already airborne)

These increased abilities will encourage the player to continuously learn, improve, and apply different skills over the course of the game. They will also encourage exploration to previously unobtainable or difficult to reach areas.

Additional abilities and items can be developed at a later date, but these elements are considered to be necessary for the MVP (minimum viable product) version of the game.

Controls

Arrow Keys	Move left and right respectively
SPACE bar	jump
Z	attack
X	Activate shield

Gameplay Balance & Pacing

The gameplay is non-linear in that the player should be encouraged to not only explore new areas, but return to previously seen ones. In order to facilitate this, certain areas or features in areas will be inaccessible to players just starting. There could be sections with incredibly complex platforming sequences that only a player experienced with the controls could successfully cross. There could be deadly boss battles that would be better fought with stronger items and an understanding of the combat. There could also simply be areas that are inaccessible until certain later game abilities are unblocked, like a platform that could only be reached with a double jump.

Another way we will facilitate the player's return to previously seen areas is designated save points. The player will not be able to respawn wherever they wish, save points will be specifically placed to ensure the difficulty of challenges can not be easily avoided. Forcing the player to re-experience sections they have already seen will encourage them to build and apply their skills, as well as look at particularly difficult challenges in new ways.

Character Design

The art style of *Monarch* is that of a traditional fairytale, taking heavy inspiration from Hans Christian Andersen's *Thumbelina* (1835). The player character is meant to be a girl in a world much larger than herself. To emphasize this, she will be the size of a normal human woman, but the non-player characters she encounters will be oversized

versions of their natural forms. Larger than natural bees, frogs, snails and other various critters will interact with our player character as both allies and enemies.
The visual style of the game will be 2D to accommodate gameplay, and ideally hand-drawn in order to recreate the feeling of a storybook one might have read in their childhood.



Setting

The game will take place in a 2D side-scroller environment, with different sections and environments for the player to explore. The environments will be themed around nature, with everything being, once again, at a much larger scale than that of reality. The goal of this stylistic choice is to create an environment in which the player feels a lack of

control. Especially at the start when they have limited skills and footing, they should be swept into a world that is far bigger than themselves.

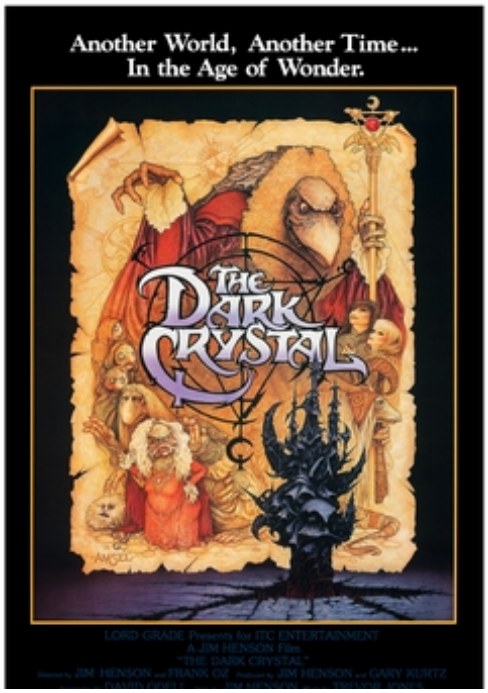
However, the prototype version of the setting should focus on facilitating mechanics more than stylistic choices. For production efficiency, the world should start as a grey-blocked map to ensure good level design and gameplay-experience. After these elements have been developed, further customization can be made to create the artistic style of the game.

Tone & Aesthetics

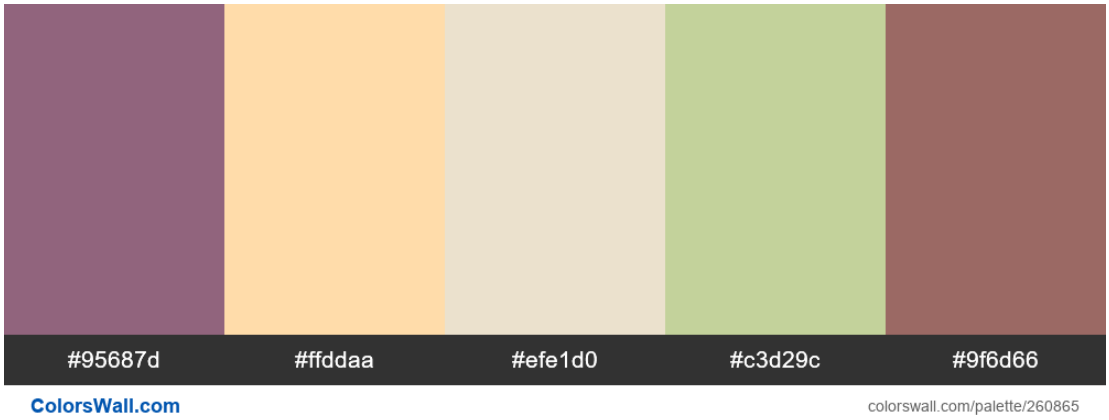
The visual style of the game is inspired by 80s dark fantasy movies, such as *The Dark Crystal* by Jim Henson, and older fairy tales like *Thumbelina* by Han Christian Anderson. This style is meant to give a mystical tone to the game, reminiscent of childhood fantasies, while still being able to carry the weight of a more serious story and convey the proper emotions to the audience.



*



**



*Thumbelina illustration by Vilhelm Perderson
**Dark Crystal poster by Richard Amsel

Business Model

The game will be released on Steam as a one-time purchase of $30 (may vary based on development), once bought players will own the game for good.
In order to facilitate an iterative development process and start to bring interest to the game, an early-access and/or demo version of the game can be released at a discounted price.
Once the game has more attention, a fundraiser (Kickstarter) can be started to help fund additional elements to the game based on development progress and player feedback.

Citations

Ashby, Steve. “How to Write a Game Design Document - with Examples and Template .” *GitBook*, www.gitbook.com/blog/how-to-write-a-game-design-document. Accessed 15 Apr. 2025.

Garneau, Pierre-Alexandre. “Fourteen Forms of Fun.” *Game Developer*, informa, 9 Nov. 2023, www.gamedeveloper.com/design/fourteen-forms-of-fun.